

THE RECORDING

An Archive of the Unknown

Elias Vance did not believe in ghosts. As an audio engineer, he believed in frequencies, reverberations, standing waves, and the logical acoustic explanations behind every supposed "bump in the night." That was why the owners of Blackwood Manor had hired him: to debunk the so-called whispering walls that had driven three consecutive sets of caretakers to break their leases in the dead of night.

Blackwood Manor was a sprawling, Victorian-era decay situated miles from the nearest town. When Elias arrived on a brisk October afternoon, the house sat beneath a canopy of dead oaks, its dark windows staring blindly into the creeping fog. He dragged his heavy Pelican cases inside, ignoring the oppressive chill that seemed to cling to the foyer's peeling wallpaper.

He set up his command center in the library, the epicenter of the reported phenomena. Cables snaked across the dusty hardwood floor like black veins, connecting high-fidelity microphones in every corner of the room to his laptop. By midnight, Elias was sitting in the dark, illuminated only by the pale blue glow of his screen, a thermos of black coffee at his elbow.

For the first three hours, the waveform on his screen was a flat, comforting line. The house was dead silent.

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At exactly 3:15 AM, the green line on his monitor spiked.

Elias bolted upright, nearly knocking over his coffee. He reached for his professional-grade headphones, slipping them over his ears. He expected the scratching of a rat in the wainscoting, or

perhaps the settling groan of century-old timber. Instead, he heard a sound that made the hair on his arms stand up.

It was a wet, rhythmic dragging sound, followed by a shallow, ragged intake of breath.

Elias quickly isolated the audio, filtering out the ambient room noise. The sound wasn't coming from outside. It was originating from Microphone 4, which was positioned near the sealed fireplace directly behind him. He spun his chair around, staring into the dark hearth. There was nothing but soot and shadow.

He turned back to the screen. The waveform was still dancing. He turned up the gain.

"Elias..."

His heart hammered against his ribs. The voice was a raspy, guttural whisper, completely devoid of gender or age. It was intimately close, as if the speaker's lips were brushing against the foam of the microphone.

"Hello?" Elias called out into the empty room, cursing himself for the tremor in his voice. "Is someone there? You're trespassing."

The waveform spiked dramatically in response. *"Not... trespassing..."* the whisper returned through the headphones. *"Waiting."*

Elias ripped the headphones off. The library was dead silent to his naked ears. Not a sound. But when he looked at the monitor, the green line was thrashing wildly, registering a cacophony of overlapping voices, screams, and wet tearing sounds that filled the digital void. The decibel levels were maxing out, yet the room itself remained utterly, impossibly quiet.

Panic, cold and sharp, finally pierced his rational mind. He reached forward to slam the laptop shut and leave. He didn't care about the equipment anymore. He just needed to get out.

As his fingers brushed the edge of the screen, the room's temperature plummeted, his breath turning to white vapor in the air. The heavy oak door of the library slammed shut with a concussive force that shook dust from the ceiling.

Then, the silence of the room finally broke.

It wasn't through the headphones this time. It was right behind him. The wet, rhythmic dragging sound echoed on the hardwood floor, moving slowly, agonizingly, toward his chair. Elias froze, unable to breathe, unable to turn around.

